

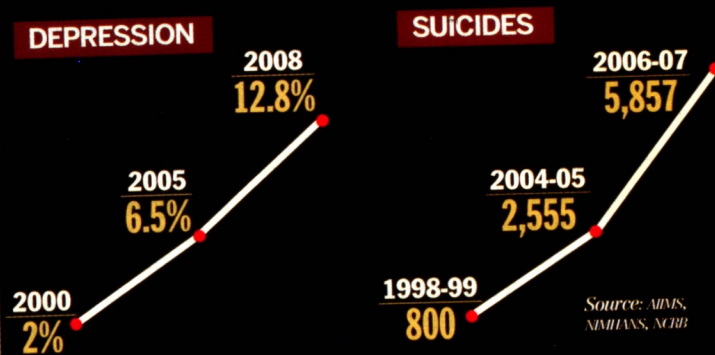
Teen SUICIDES

BEING A TEENAGER HAS NEVER BEEN EASY. INDIA TOPS THE WORLD IN TEEN SUICIDES AS EXAM STRESS AND DEPRESSION BECOME KEY FACTORS, BUT OTHER URBAN PRESSURES ARE ALSO TAKING A HEAVY TOLL. IS GROWING UP MORE TRYING THAN EVER?

■ By Damayanti Datta

Deep inside the U-shaped complex of Delhi's premier All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), the clock clicks against the heavy silence in psychiatrist Manju Mehta's chamber. A mother sits huddled in front of her. "I want to say sorry for not listening to you," she stutters as she talks and searches for words, her eyes welling with tears. Neither she nor her husband had accepted Mehta's diagnosis that behind her son's falling grades and temper tantrums, lay learning disability and severe depression. "Conduct disorder is his way of gaining self-respect," Mehta had told them. The parents, more interested in improving his school performance, had not heeded the advice, "Don't put pressure on him." Just before the annual exams, he had suddenly turned over a new leaf: he was nice to everyone, listened to everything his parents said, met up with people he was fond of. Finally, one afternoon, he took his own life. "I quit," read the chit lying on his bed.

RISING TIDE: Depression, anxiety, stress and suicides among teenagers are mounting across the country...



56%

teen suicides in the country are reported between March and July every year

16

suicides a day, or 6,000 a year, is the rate at which teenagers snuff out their lives in India